ZP-I Illustrated Companion

Going Forward Brings You Back to Zero

Inside Zero

ZP Companion | Initial: April 2026 | Current: 1.45, November 2026

This companion explains in plain language how a 2-adic depth chain $S_0, S_1, S_2, \ldots$ converges, in the 2-adic metric, to zero - and why the framework READS that limit as filling the bottom role again. Both that reading and whether the result is a NEW bottom or the one it started from are commitments of the framework, not things the chain proves. This is one result in the Zero Paradox project (ZP-I), a formal framework built on lattice algebra and 2-adic topology. Diagrams and real-world examples are included throughout. It is self-contained: ZP-A through ZP-E results used here are briefly introduced on first appearance. Every claim restates a result already proved in the corresponding technical document - consult that document for the authoritative mathematics. (The ZP-E Illustrated Companion covers the upstream results in more depth if needed.)

What Is ZP-I Doing?

ZP-E proved that the transition from $\bot$ to ε_0 (c_0 to c_1 on MachinePhase) has its SHAPE fixed by the lattice axioms - derived, not assumed; that the transition is taken is a further commitment. But ZP-E left a question open: what happens after the Snap? The chain of states ascends - but does it ascend forever? And if not, what comes next?

ZP-I answers both questions with a single theorem: T-IZ (Inside Zero). Every 2-adic depth chain $S_0, S_1, S_2, \ldots$ with no zero term, whose 2-adic valuations track a depth index (IsDepthChain) that climbs at every step (IsStrictStateSequence, a condition on that index), converges - in the 2-adic metric - to zero, which the framework reads as the bottom role and then as a successor null. The chain runs through every finite stage and reaches its limit at ω, the first limit ordinal. The convergence is proved (given the IsDepthChain modelling commitment), and so, separately, is the fact that anything filling the bottom role IS the bottom already there. That the cycle begins again at the limit is a reading, not a theorem: see the Note on closure.

The name "Inside Zero" refers to the geometry of the approach. The chain does not reach zero by turning around and going backward. It reaches zero by going deeper - descending into the 2-adic structure until the depth of zero is reached from the inside. Forward motion is the mechanism of return. (Reading that zero as a new null $\bot'$ is a commitment, not something the chain proves.)

What the No-Top Property Does

Where the state space $(L, \vee, \bot)$ has no top element, there is no maximum state. That is a condition on the carrier, not a law of every lattice here: the two-state carriers MachinePhase and OntologicalStates have a top. Stated on its own this looks like a limitation - the algebra does not close. ZP-I reveals it is the opposite: it is what gives T-IZ room to run. ⚠ Two cautions. It is NOT ZP-A's Remark R1, which is the no-subtraction restriction (Door 1 below); the order property is HasNoTop, in ZeroParadox/Order/Lattice.lean. And it does NOT put the limit outside L - whether a limit escapes its carrier depends on the lattice, and the ordinals

under max have no top while the chain n to n has least upper bound omega inside them.

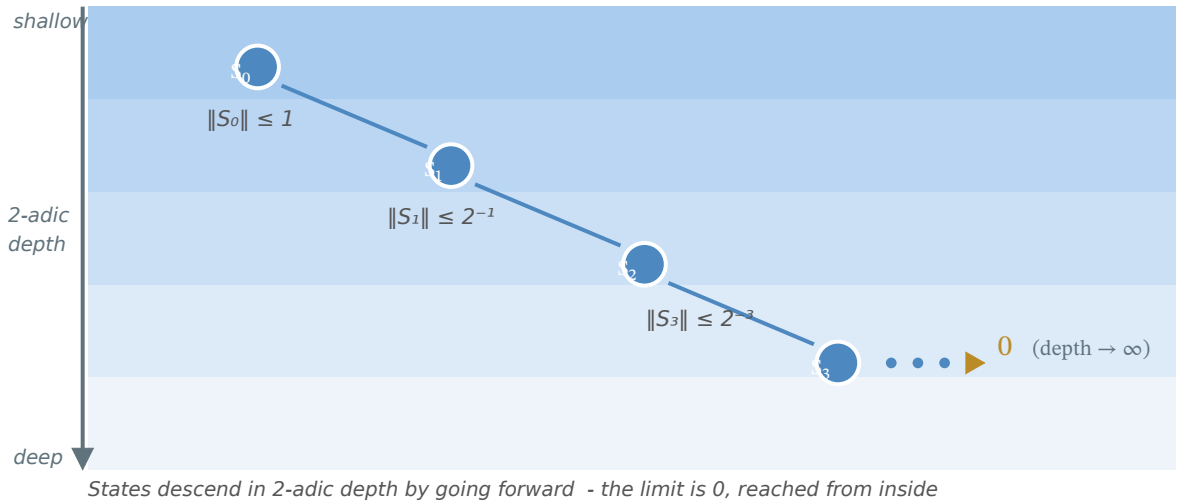
Here is the logic. The IsDepthChain modelling commitment links two carriers: a depth index in ℕ, and a chain of 2-adic numbers whose 2-adic valuation depth - a measure of how many times 2 divides the number - equals that index. As the index ascends (ZP-A T3: every step is a join, every state is at least as large as the last), the depth increases. Where L has no top element, the chain never HAS to stop - there is always a strictly greater element. Given that it keeps stepping, the depth grows without bound.

More than that: each step is a genuine advance. The depth does not merely grow eventually - given the IsDepthChain condition, it increases by at least 1 at every transition. This is derived, not assumed separately. Two stated conditions give it: IsDepthChain, which sets the chain's 2-adic valuation EQUAL to a depth index in ℕ at every step, and IsStrictStateSequence on that index, which says every step is a PROPER ascent (monotone by T3, and never standing still). Together they give depth growth of at least 1 per step (h_strict_from_r1_t3). The geometric norm bound used below needs a third condition, that no term of the chain is zero (t_iz_r1_t3_geometric_bound). No-top supplies the room for that ascent and is not itself a hypothesis of the theorem: HasNoTop appears in none of these binders (SemilatticeInstance.lean §Ib, with a NO-GO gauge exhibiting a no-top lattice whose chain never moves).

In the 2-adic metric, norms decrease geometrically: $\|S(n)\| \leq \|S(0)\| \cdot 2^{-n}$. As $n \to \infty$, the norm $\to 0$. The chain converges to 0 in the 2-adic sense: the point with 2-adic valuation $+\infty$ under the usual convention $v_2(0) = \infty$. Reading that structural limit as filling the bottom role takes a choice of join on Q_2 - the role condition is not statable of the limit until a join on Q_2 is chosen, and then it is that semilattice's $\perp$ by theorem (t_iz_limit_is_new_null) - and calling the occupant $\perp'$, a successor null, is C-DA2, a commitment; in this very chart the arc returns to the same 0.

Real-world analogy - The deepest point in the well

Imagine a well that has no bottom - every level opens onto a deeper one. You descend, level by level, and each step takes you to a place more "inside" the well than the last. You never hit a floor within the well. But from the outside, there is a limit to all that descent - the point that all those levels approach. In ZP-I, that limit is 2-adic zero. Reading it as the bottom of a lattice is a reading across two different structures, and reading it as a NEW bottom is a commitment.



States descend in 2-adic depth by going forward - the limit is 0, reached from inside

The 2-adic chain $S_0, S_1, S_2, \ldots$ descends in 2-adic depth as the depth index it is linked to by the IsDepthChain modelling commitment ascends. As depth $\to \infty$, the 2-adic norm $\to 0$. The chain converges to zero from inside, not by reversing

direction.

> The no-top property is not a limitation. In a carrier that has it (not every carrier does), it guarantees the road never ends: there is always somewhere further to go, so no chain halts for want of room. What makes a particular chain travel it is the assumption that every step is a proper ascent. No-top buys the POSSIBILITY; the strict-ascent condition is the OCCURRENCE. Where the road ENDS UP - inside the lattice or outside it - is a separate question no-top does not settle.

The Geometry of Going Inside

The 2-adic metric is unusual. In the ordinary real number line, "close to zero" means "small absolute value." In the 2-adic metric, "close to zero" means "divisible by a very high power of 2." These are different geometries, and in the 2-adic geometry, the natural motion of the depth chain is toward zero, not away from it.

Think of it this way: each number in the 2-adic chain is divisible by 2^n for some n. As the depth index it is linked to ascends - each index "larger" in the lattice sense - the number becomes divisible by higher and higher powers of 2. In 2-adic terms, this means it is getting closer to 0. The chain approaches zero by becoming more and more structured, not by becoming smaller.

The formal statement uses the geometric norm bound: $\|S(n)\|_2 \leq \|S(0)\|_2 \cdot 2^{-n}$. This bound is derived in Lean 4 as theorem t_iz_r1_t3_geometric_bound - using the p-adic norm formula and monotonicity of the valuation (T3 plus strict ascent). It means the norm is squeezed toward 0 by a geometric sequence, forcing convergence.

T-IZ in Plain Language

The theorem has four steps, and t_iz_complete (ZeroParadox/Valuation/SemilatticeInstance.lean §III-B) carries all four in Lean 4. Read what it joins and what it does not: step 1 is about 0 in Q_2, while steps 2 to 4 are about a terminal in a separate semilattice, and the theorem takes the bottom-role property as a hypothesis rather than deriving it for the limit. The two objects are never identified, so this is a conjunction of results, not a single chain:

Step	What it says	Source
1. Cauchy convergence	The chain has 2-adic norm $\leq 2^{-n}$ at step n. Both the norm and the chain converge to 0. This is the topological core.	The geometric norm bound - proved (no sorryAx) (t_iz_cauchy, which binds the chain and the bound and no lattice at all; completeness of Q_2 is not consumed, because the limit is exhibited as 0 rather than obtained from a Cauchy criterion). Strict per-step growth follows from h_strict_from_r1_t3 + IsDepthChain - verified as a derived condition. ✓
2. ⊥-role identification	Anything satisfying the join-identity condition IS that lattice's bottom. That the Cauchy limit $0 \in Q_2$ satisfies it is the theorem's HYPOTHESIS, not its conclusion, and Q_2's field structure supplies no join (the corpus registers none on Q_2), so the condition is not statable there — the two are distinct members of the bottom family, not one object (MC-1). Reading the occupant as a NEW null ⊥′ is a further commitment (C-DA2).	ZP-E DA-2 - proved in Lean (t_iz_limit_is_new_null, axiom-free). ✓ (the role only, given the hypothesis; not the novelty)
3. ⊥ of L′ is its Quine atom, given a KleeneStructure	Given a KleeneStructure on a semilattice L′ (ZP-K), the ⊥ of L′ is its Quine atom (da1_computational). That L′ is the successor of this limit is the occupancy and C-DA2 reading, not established here. DA-1 itself applies only on the limit reaching P_0 (which nothing here establishes), and needs DP-2 and DP-2's precondition, which the occurrence commitment asserts and DA-1 consumes (ZP-E); this step supplies none of these.	da1_computational - proved in Lean, given the KleeneStructure instance ✓
4. T-SNAP fires, conditionally	On the reading that the limit fills the ⊥ role, on the limit reaching P_0 (which nothing here establishes), and on what DA-1 needs (step 3), at the computational fixed point T-SNAP fires: join $\perp\ \varepsilon_0' = \varepsilon_0'$. Reading the 2-adic limit as the occupant is one commitment; calling that occupant a NEW null ⊥′ rather than the same ⊥ is a second.	ZP-A bot_join - proved in Lean. ✓ (the algebra, given the reading; neither the occupancy nor the novelty)

Theorem T-IZ - Inside Zero

Every sequence $S_0, S_1, S_2, \ldots$ of 2-adic numbers with no zero term, whose 2-adic valuations equal a depth index in $\mathbb{N}$ (IsDepthChain) that climbs at every step (IsStrictStateSequence) - converges to zero in the 2-adic metric. Starting at $\bot$ and climbing by ZP-A T3 are statements about the depth index and the lattice chain, not about the 2-adic numbers, which have no order of that kind. Reading the limit as filling the bottom role is a commitment, and reading the occupant as $\bot'$ a further one. On the first reading, DA-1 and then T-SNAP are CONDITIONAL on the limit reaching P_0 (which nothing here establishes) and on what DA-1 needs. DA-1 needs DP-2 and DP-2's precondition, that the configuration reaching the incompressibility threshold P_0 is a running machine's current configuration and not an inert string; that precondition is what the occurrence commitment asserts, and DA-1 consumes it and does not supply it (ZP-E § IV). Nothing here establishes that the limit reaches P_0: its only route in ZP-I is refuted (ZP-I § II.B). t_iz_complete takes a KleeneStructure on the limit's successor semilattice as a hypothesis and links that semilattice to nothing; its DA-1 conjunct, that the semilattice's $\bot$ is its Quine atom, is the Lean counterpart of DA-1's Path 1, which does not derive the precondition. The CONVERGENCE needs no new axioms (its Lean proof carries Mathlib's Classical.choice) and rests on the IsDepthChain modelling commitment; the two readings are commitments rather than consequences of it. That the chain generates a genuinely NEW bottom, rather than arriving back at the one it started from, is the framework's commitment and not something the chain proves - in the 2-adic picture the arc comes back to the same 0.

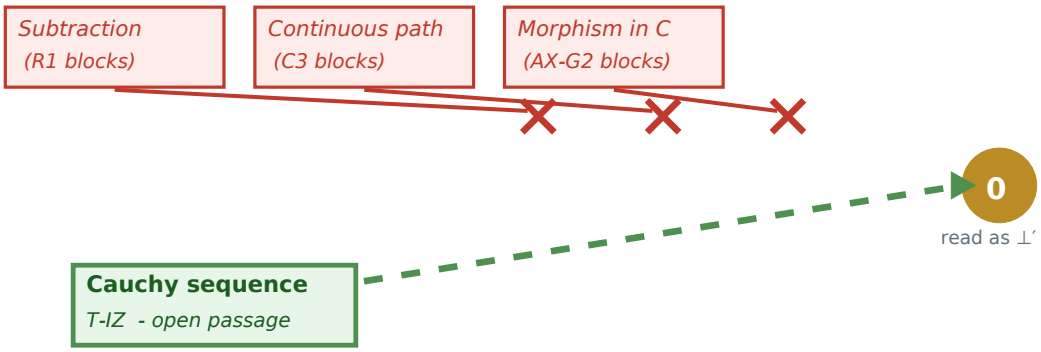
Three Closed Doors, One Open Passage

ZP-I does not violate any of the irreversibility results already proved. The framework established three ways that return to $\bot$ is blocked - three "closed doors." T-IZ uses a fourth passage that none of the three doors govern. The doors are a picture, not a theorem: they are statements about three different objects, and the fourth passage reaches 0 in Q_2 only as a limit: no stage of the chain is 0, and the limit is 0, so the chain reaches 0 without passing through any of the three doors. In this chart the arc comes back to the same 0 (snap_arc_z2_loop). Reading that 0 as filling the bottom role takes a choice of join on Q_2 (then it is that semilattice's $\bot$ by theorem, t_iz_limit_is_new_null), and reading it as a successor null is C-DA2, a commitment.

Door 1 - R1 (No subtraction): In the lattice, there is no subtraction. You cannot join your way back to a smaller state. The ascending chain never subtracts - every step is a join $S_{n+1} = S_n \vee \alpha_n$. T-IZ does not subtract. The chain joins forward, and the 2-adic geometry means "forward" is also "deeper." R1 is not an obstacle to T-IZ, and it is not a source of it either. What leaves the chain somewhere to go, in a carrier that has it, is the separate order property HasNoTop, and what makes the valuation climb is strict ascent.

Door 2 - C3 (No continuous path to zero): ZP-B proved there is no continuous function $\gamma : [0,1] \to Q_2$ with $\gamma(0) \neq 0$ and $\gamma(1) = 0$. T-IZ uses a Cauchy sequence - a discrete countable list of points - not a continuous function on an interval. C3's prohibition covers continuous paths; it says nothing about Cauchy sequences. Proved in Lean: t_iz_c3_compatible.

Door 3 - AX-G2 (No morphism to initial object): ZP-G's axiom AX-G2 states that no morphism within the categorical structure C leads back to the initial object. T-IZ is not a morphism within C: it is a convergence statement about 2-adic numbers. Reading its limit as the termination of C and the opening of a new C', with its own $\bot'$, is the cycle reading, not a result (see the Note on closure). AX-G2 quantifies over morphisms within a single category; it says nothing about transitions between categories.



Three structures block return to zero. Cauchy convergence is the passage none of them govern.

Three structures block return to zero: algebraic (R1), topological (C3), categorical (AX-G2). The fourth passage - Cauchy sequence convergence - is not governed by any of them. T-IZ passes through the fourth door.

Irreversibility and inside convergence are not in tension. Irreversibility (R1, C3, AX-G2) governs motion within an instantiation: no subtraction, no continuous return, no categorical reversal. T-IZ governs what happens at the instantiation's ordinal limit: the chain converges, by Cauchy convergence, to 2-adic zero, which the framework reads as filling the bottom role - a structure that irreversibility does not reach. Reading that occupant as its own SUCCESSOR null is the commitment.

The Cycle Reading

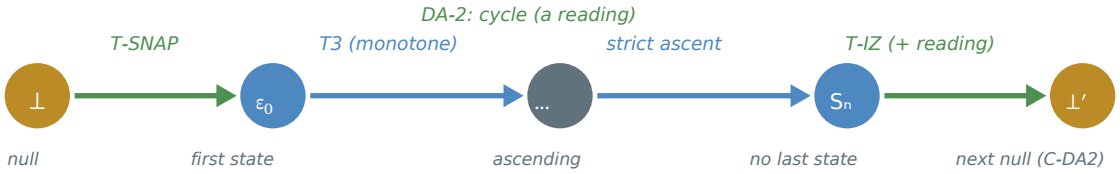
ZP-E gave us the beginning: T-SNAP ($\bot \to \varepsilon_0$ - shape derived, occurrence committed to). ZP-I gives us the convergence: T-IZ (the chain $\to 0$, read as the bottom role, and as $\bot'$ only on a commitment). The framework reads the two together as a repeating cycle. That cycle is a reading, not a theorem: see the Note on closure below.

1. T-SNAP fires: $\bot$ and ε_0 emerge. The branch opens.
2. T3 (monotonicity): states ascend. Each step adds informational content irreversibly.
3. No top: in a carrier that has no top, the chain never has to stop - there is always a strictly greater state. That it DOES keep ascending through ω state changes is the strict-ascent condition. (Not ZP-A's R1, which is Door 1, no subtraction.)

Occurrence fence. T-SNAP fixes the SHAPE of each step and does not establish that any step is taken; a model in which T-SNAP holds and nothing moves is exhibited in the Lean source. Throughout this document, "fires" narrates the framework's occurrence commitment - before this note as well as after it. The occurrence commitment is stated in two charts, execution and slot, in the header of ZeroParadox/Order/Snap.lean (indexed in ZeroParadox/Order/SnapCannotBe.lean § II and CLAIMS.md), the slot chart as the hypothesis hw of t_snap_of_fires_once, that the tape fires at some stage, beside the theorem trials_fires_once that, for independent stages each firing with probability p, $0 < p \leq 1$, firing at some stage has probability one, which names no tape (ZeroParadox/Information/CrossingTrials.lean § VIII).

4. T-IZ: the chain's unbounded depth forces convergence to 0. That DA-1 and T-SNAP fire again there, closing the branch, is a reading: see the Note on closure.
5. DA-2: $\bot'$ is read as the foundation of the next instantiation, and the cycle repeats; this too is a reading: see

the Note on closure.



The cycle reading: T-SNAP opens the branch, strict ascent climbs it, and T-IZ's 2-adic chain converges to 0. The return to ⊥′ and the cycle are a reading, not a theorem: see the Note on closure.

Two charts, two carriers. In the 2-adic numbers, the chain converges to 2-adic zero: zero is the LIMIT, not a term, since no term of the chain is zero. The field structure of the 2-adic numbers supplies no join, and the corpus registers none on them, so the bottom role is not statable of the limit here. (A join could be chosen, since every inhabited set admits one; on the 2-adic integers the corpus supplies one with zero as its bottom (ZeroParadox/Valuation/Scale.lean § V), and zero filling that bottom is a choice of operation, not something T-IZ derives.) In a join-semilattice, the bottom ROLE is the element that leaves everything unchanged under join, and anything filling it IS that semilattice's existing ⊥. Reading the 2-adic limit as filling that role is a reading across the two carriers, not an identity (MC-1). That the ⊥ so reached is a NEW one is the C-DA2 commitment; in the 2-adic picture the arc comes back to the same 0.

Note on closure: T-IZ does not establish a closed system, and the cycle is a reading, not a theorem. What T-IZ proves is that the 2-adic depth chain converges to 0 in the 2-adic metric, given the IsDepthChain modelling commitment, IsStrictStateSequence and no term being zero; separately, anything filling the bottom role IS the bottom already there (t_iz_limit_is_new_null). In Lean, t_iz_complete is a conjunction of results, not a chain, and its role step takes its property as the hypothesis h_role, which nothing here grounds. For the cycle to begin again or close at the limit, it needs every one of the following further premises, and none is established here: (a) the reading that the limit fills the ⊥ role, a commitment and a reading across two carriers (MC-1); (b) the limit reaching the incompressibility threshold P_0, which nothing here establishes, since its only route in ZP-I is refuted (ZP-I § II.B); (c) what DA-1 needs: DP-2 and DP-2's precondition, that the configuration reaching P_0 is a running machine's current configuration and not an inert string, which the occurrence commitment asserts and DA-1 consumes and does not supply (ZP-E § IV); and (d) for the next branch to start from a new null ⊥′ rather than the same ⊥, C-DA2, a further commitment; in the 2-adic picture the arc comes back to the same 0. Whether the successor instantiation is part of a single formal structure or requires an extended framework is a question about multi-instantiation scope, not about the derivation itself.

Lean 4 Verification

T-IZ is carried in Lean 4 (ZeroParadox/Valuation/SemilatticeInstance.lean). All four steps appear in one theorem, as a conjunction: the role step takes its property as a hypothesis and is never joined to the 2-adic limit. Axiom-free results are noted individually in the table below.

Lean 4 Verification Status (SemilatticeInstance.lean - all proofs filled, no sorry)

h_strict_from_r1_t3 (§Ib) - derives strict per-step valuation growth from IsDepthChain + IsStrictStateSequence (2-adic depth tracks position index). Closes R-IZ-A: strict growth is no longer a construction hypothesis. ✓

t_iz_norm_tendsto_zero - norm bound $\leq 2^{-n}$ implies norms converge to 0. Proved via squeeze_zero + tendsto_pow_atTop_nhds_zero_of_lt_one. ✓ (no sorryAx)

t_iz_conv_zero - norm convergence implies sequence convergence in Q_2. Proved via tendsto_zero_iff_norm_tendsto_zero. ✓ (no sorryAx)

t_iz_r1_t3_geometric_bound - derives $\|S(n)\| \leq \|S(0)\| \cdot 2^{-n}$ from the chain being nowhere zero and its valuation strictly increasing at every step. Uses Padic.norm_eq_zpow_neg_valuation + zpow_le_zpow_right$_0$. ✓

t_iz_cauchy - the complete topological convergence result. ✓ (no sorryAx)

t_iz_limit_is_new_null - anything satisfying the DA-2 null role IS that lattice's bottom (⊥-role identification). The role property is the HYPOTHESIS; that the Cauchy limit satisfies it is not established here and is not statable of the limit until a join on Q_2 is chosen. Reading that occupant as ⊥′ is C-DA2, a further commitment. Proved directly from da2_bottom_characterization. ✓ (axiom-free)

da1_computational - proved in Lean, given the KleeneStructure instance ✓

t_iz_complete (§III-B) - carries all four steps in one theorem: convergence, ⊥-role identification, DA-1, T-SNAP. All formal, no Kolmogorov complexity needed. ✓ (a conjunction, not a chain: the convergence step is about Q_2 and the role step about a terminal in a separate semilattice, taken as the hypothesis h_role and not identified with the limit)

t_iz_complete_from_axioms (§III-C, optional) - replaces the h_bound hypothesis with three: the chain is nowhere zero, IsDepthChain, and IsStrictStateSequence. Only the last is a ZP-A lattice condition; IsDepthChain is the bridge saying the 2-adic valuation tracks the depth index, and it binds no semilattice. ✓ It also still carries h_role explicitly, which is the one hypothesis nothing here grounds.

c_t_iz_null_balance - a non-bottom state cannot fill the bottom role. Proved from c_da2_novelty. ✓

t_iz_c3_compatible - C3 irreversibility and T-IZ coexist. Cauchy sequences ≠ continuous paths. ✓

ZP-I Summary

T-IZ requires no new axioms. All four steps are carried in Lean 4 (ZeroParadox/Valuation/SemilatticeInstance.lean, t_iz_complete) as a conjunction, with the role step's property taken as a hypothesis. The Kolmogorov complexity route is refuted: 2-adic depth growing without bound does not make a state incompressible, since 2^n has depth n and is computed from n by one short program (ZP-I § II.B). That route is not load-bearing: the convergence T-IZ proves does not pass through it. DA-1 is closed given DP-2 (ZP-E), with ZP-K witnessing Path 1 and carrying Path 3 as a KleeneStructure requirement. Emergence and return are derived only as far as the CONVERGENCE and the role-recognition implication. The cycle is a reading, not a theorem: see the Note on closure.